

# Beyond the Hashtag: Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion Strategies in Canadian Sexual Assault Centres? Social Media

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## Abstract

Social media has become an essential communication infrastructure for sexual assault (SA) and intimate partner violence (IPV) centres, yet these platforms were not designed for trauma-informed or equity-oriented communication. We present findings from 43 interviews with staff managing Canadian SA/IPV centres' official social media accounts. Participants described enacting equity, diversity, and inclusion (EDI) through intersectional representation, accessibility practices, and non-triggering language, while navigating community stigma and platform moderation systems that routinely suppress SA-related content. These tensions expose the invisible labour required to sustain survivor safety, organizational visibility, and digital trust. By examining equity-centered communication in a safety-critical context, this work offers design insights for future research on trauma-informed moderation, equitable visibility, and safer interaction management in social media systems, informing the design of future trauma-informed social media systems.

## CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing;

## Keywords

social media, sexual assault, intimate partner violence

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## 1 Introduction

The integration of Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion (EDI) principles into social media practice is increasingly central for organizations supporting sexual assault (SA) and intimate partner violence (IPV) survivors—particularly because many survivors experience intersecting forms of marginalization and face barriers to accessing support [44]. Social media platforms have become essential infrastructures for outreach, education, and community engagement for these organizations, yet they also introduce risks that are difficult to reconcile with trauma-informed, equity-centered communication. Prior work highlights the prevalence and impact of online harassment and gendered hostility [45], underscoring how digital environments can reproduce stigma and harm even when organizations aim to create safer spaces.

Within this context, EDI is not merely a set of values but a practical requirement shaping how SA/IPV centres communicate online. A trauma-informed approach—often closely aligned with EDI—emphasizes safety, trustworthiness, and cultural sensitivity, and is particularly relevant when posts may be encountered by survivors in vulnerable moments [38]. At the same time, accessibility constitutes a core component of inclusion, yet non-profits frequently struggle to meet accessibility standards due to limited resources and expertise [13, 24]. Recent studies also suggest that diversity- and inclusion-oriented content can affect engagement and community-building dynamics on social media [20, 28]. However, these insights offer limited guidance for highly stigmatized and safety-critical domains such as SA/IPV support, where visibility, language, and moderation choices can directly influence perceived trust and risk.

Despite growing recognition of EDI in digital communication [28], there remains limited understanding of how SA/IPV non-profits operationalize EDI under the combined pressures of community stigma and platform constraints. Survivors and the organizations

that support them operate within environments shaped by entrenched misconceptions, polarized public discourse, and platform governance mechanisms that may restrict sensitive content. HCI and CSCW research has examined harassment, trauma, and harmful online interactions, as well as the ways platform design shapes marginalized users' experiences [37, 45]. Building on these conversations, we examine how SA/IPV centres integrate EDI into everyday social media work—how they craft inclusive and non-triggering content, respond to stigmatizing interactions, and adapt communication practices to platform-level limitations.

To address this gap, we conducted semi-structured interviews with staff from 43 SA/IPV centres across Canada. Our study examines how these organizations operationalize EDI principles in their social media work while navigating community stigma, organizational mandates, and platform-level constraints. By foregrounding the practical tensions and value-driven decisions that shape equity-centered communication in high-stakes environments, this research extends HCI scholarship on social computing, digital safety, and technology-mediated care. Taken together, this work contributes: (1) a qualitative account of how EDI values are materialized through everyday social media practices in safety-critical nonprofits, and (2) a characterization of the sociotechnical tensions that shape equity-centered communication amid community, organizational, and platform pressures.

## 2 Related Work

### 2.1 Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion in Organizational and Digital Contexts

Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion (EDI) principles are widely recognized as foundational for creating environments in which individuals from diverse backgrounds can participate meaningfully and equitably. Equity emphasizes fairness and justice by acknowledging differing needs and structural barriers, diversity reflects the presence of difference across dimensions such as race, gender, sexuality, age, and disability, and inclusion concerns whether individuals feel valued and able to participate fully within a given context [39]. Emerging from civil rights movements, EDI frameworks have expanded over time to encompass gender equality, disability rights, and LGBTQ+ rights across sectors [47].

In North America and beyond, EDI principles have been applied across education, healthcare, corporate, and non-profit settings to address systemic inequities and improve organizational outcomes [5, 26, 35]. Canadian policy frameworks, including the Canadian Multiculturalism Act and the Employment Equity Act, further institutionalize commitments to diversity and workplace equity [1]. Despite these efforts, prior work consistently notes challenges in translating EDI commitments into everyday practice, including resistance to change, unconscious bias, and structural inequalities embedded within organizations and systems [32, 36].

Recent research has begun to examine how EDI principles intersect with digital communication and social media, suggesting that inclusion-oriented content can shape engagement, representation, and community dynamics online [20, 28]. However, this body of work largely focuses on corporate or public-facing communication and offers limited insight into how EDI is operationalized in highly

sensitive, stigmatized domains where digital visibility and safety are deeply intertwined.

### 2.2 Sexual Assault, Intimate Partner Violence, and the Role of Support Organizations

Sexual assault (SA) and intimate partner violence (IPV) remain pervasive social issues in Canada, with disproportionate impacts on marginalized populations, including LGBTQ2SIA+ individuals, Indigenous communities, racialized groups, and people with disabilities [14, 15, 33, 44]. Survivors often face significant barriers to disclosure and help-seeking due to stigma, misinformation, and fear of social or institutional repercussions. These barriers were further exacerbated during the COVID-19 pandemic, when isolation measures limited access to informal support networks and increased exposure to violence within private spaces [2, 7].

SA and IPV organizations play a critical role in responding to these challenges by providing survivor-centered, trauma-informed care, including crisis response, medical and psychological support, and advocacy services [19, 27]. Beyond direct service provision, these organizations engage in public education, policy advocacy, and community outreach aimed at challenging stigma and preventing violence [10]. In Canada, sexual assault and domestic violence centres operate across provinces and linguistic contexts, often functioning not only as service providers but also as sites of social activism and collective advocacy [4, 11].

Research examining the organizational experiences of SA/IPV centres highlights persistent challenges related to funding instability, resource constraints, and gendered labor dynamics, which were intensified during the COVID-19 pandemic [30]. These pressures shape how organizations communicate, prioritize outreach, and engage with digital technologies, yet existing work has largely focused on organizational resilience rather than everyday communication practices.

### 2.3 Non-Profit Use of ICT and Social Media in Sensitive Contexts

Non-profit organizations increasingly rely on information and communication technologies (ICT), particularly social media, to support advocacy, relationship-building, and public engagement [6, 12]. Prior studies suggest that social media enables non-profits to cultivate transparency, mobilize communities, and strengthen ties with stakeholders, including donors and volunteers [17, 40]. However, effective use of these platforms is shaped by organizational size, resources, digital literacy, and strategic capacity [3, 16, 22].

For organizations working in sensitive domains, such as SA and IPV support, the use of social media introduces additional complexities. While digital platforms can expand outreach, particularly to younger or geographically isolated populations [42, 46], they also raise concerns around confidentiality, privacy, and exposure to online abuse [9, 18, 34]. Research has documented how survivors and advocates encounter harassment, cyberstalking, and hostile interactions online, underscoring the need for cautious and context-aware communication strategies [25, 41].

Within the HCI and CSCW literature, scholars have examined online harassment, content moderation, and the risks faced by

marginalized users in social media environments [37, 45]. Yet comparatively little attention has been paid to how non-profit organizations supporting survivors navigate these dynamics in their everyday social media work—particularly in national contexts such as Canada, where existing research remains limited [31]. This study builds on prior work by examining how SA/IPV centres integrate EDI principles into social media practices while managing platform constraints and community stigma.

### 3 Method

We conducted a qualitative study with staff from sexual assault (SA) and intimate partner violence (IPV) centres across Canada to examine how organizations integrate EDI principles into their social media practices. The study received university ethics approval.

#### 3.1 Participants and Recruitment

We contacted 206 SA/IPV organizations via email, telephone, or social media, reaching out up to five times. Forty-three organizations agreed to participate (response rate: 20.87%), which aligns with similar interview-based studies [21]. Eligible participants were paid staff members who (1) worked in SA/IPV centres, (2) had experience managing the organization's official social media accounts, and (3) spoke English. Volunteers, interns, and staff affiliated for less than three months were excluded. Participating organizations represented diverse regions and service models. We verified each centre's social media presence (Facebook, Instagram, Twitter, YouTube, or LinkedIn) through website checks before recruitment. Participants received a \$50 electronic gift card as compensation.

#### 3.2 Procedure

Eligible participants completed semi-structured interviews conducted over Zoom. After informed consent, each participant took part in a 30–60 minute interview. Interviews followed established qualitative protocols used in SA/IPV and nonprofit social media research [23, 29, 42]. Interviews were audio-recorded, transcribed using Zoom transcription, and cleaned manually for accuracy.

The interview guide focused on organizational social media practices, including community stigma, platform constraints, and EDI-related decisions. For example, participants were asked how their centres navigate stigma online, how platform moderation policies shape communication, and how equity or anti-oppressive practices inform content design. Interviews were conducted in English, though original bilingual questions were included for centres serving Francophone communities.

As the study did not involve survivors directly, questions were designed to minimize emotional burden on staff while allowing them to discuss organizational constraints and equity considerations.

#### 3.3 Data Analysis

We conducted inductive thematic analysis [8]. Researchers first read all transcripts for familiarization, then generated initial codes capturing recurring ideas related to EDI, representation, stigma, and platform navigation. Codes were iteratively grouped into themes

and subthemes, with refinements made through ongoing comparison across transcripts. Dedoose was used to support coding and organization of themes.

## 4 Findings

Across 43 interviews, staff revealed a set of tensions that were sharper and more systemic than expected: despite organizations' public-facing role, SA/IPV-related posts are routinely hidden, restricted, or downranked by automated moderation. These dynamics forced centres to adopt coded or euphemistic language to ensure educational and safety-critical information remained visible to survivors. Building on this, our analysis identifies three themes that illustrate how intersectional commitments, survivor-safe communication, and multi-level constraints shape equity-oriented social media work.

### 4.1 Intersectionality as Ongoing Articulation Work

Across interviews, participants emphasized that intersectionality was not merely an organizational value but an orientation that shaped routine choices about representation, voice, and the framing of survivorship. Staff described beginning content creation by identifying which communities a post needed to acknowledge—such as Indigenous, BIPOC, or gender-diverse survivors—and ensuring this intention was visible in language and imagery. As one participant noted, “When we post, we start by asking who this is for, and we make that explicit.” (P8)

Participants also described efforts to challenge dominant survivor stereotypes, which often center white, cisgender, middle-class women. Several interviewees framed their work as expanding public imagination around who is impacted by SA/IPV, and how intersecting forms of oppression shape these experiences. This required careful choices about whose voices were amplified, which narratives were highlighted, and what forms of violence were named. One participant explained, “People imagine one kind of survivor; we try to demystify that and show how oppression intersects with violence.” (P43)

For organizations serving Indigenous and queer communities, intersectional work also involved relational practices such as partnering with trusted local groups or reposting community-generated materials. Participants noted that this approach helped prevent “speaking for” marginalized communities and instead centered their knowledge and lived experience. As one practitioner put it, “We work from a decolonized perspective and let communities speak for themselves.” (P12) These examples show how intersectionality becomes operationalized through micro-decisions in everyday social media work.

### 4.2 Safety and Accessibility as Everyday Design Labor

Participants described social media as a space requiring ongoing emotional and ethical labour to ensure safety for diverse survivors. Trauma-informed communication practices—including neutral tone, anticipatory clarification, and avoidance of triggering wording—were consistently cited as foundational. Staff noted their intent to maintain clarity and inclusivity while reducing cognitive

load: “We use gender-neutral language, keep things simple, and make sure no one feels excluded.” (P37)

Accessibility was widely acknowledged as essential but unevenly implemented due to limited training and resources. Many centres recognized the need for alt text, reduced jargon, and content structured for screen readers, but reported difficulty implementing these practices consistently amid competing demands. As one participant admitted, “Alt text is an equity issue, but we haven’t integrated it into our routine practice yet.” (P10) Others described similar gaps between commitment and execution, naming accessibility as an area of ongoing improvement rather than established practice.

Moderation emerged as another aspect of survivor-centered care. Staff frequently evaluated comments through the imagined lens of a survivor scrolling past. This shaped decisions to hide stigmatizing content, restrict replies, or redirect disclosures to private channels. As one participant explained, “If I think a survivor would feel triggered reading a comment, I hide it—that’s my threshold.” (P8) These decisions illustrate how operational tasks such as comment moderation became extensions of frontline support work.

### 4.3 Multi-level Constraints on Equity-Centered Communication

Participants described encountering stigma from community members, especially in rural or conservative areas where posts supporting gender-diverse or queer survivors prompted unfollows or negative comments. Some staff reported pressure to modulate messaging in anticipation of backlash shaped by local political cultures or cultural taboos around discussing sexual violence publicly. These dynamics created tension between organizational commitments to equity and the pragmatic need to maintain community trust.

Organizational mandates also constrained what could be said online. Some participants described being discouraged from addressing systemic contributors to sexual violence—such as policing, structural discrimination, or power dynamics—despite viewing these topics as central to their work. One participant recalled being instructed to remove content addressing policing: “I posted about the police system and was told not to talk about it in that way.” (P6) These experiences reflect internal negotiations between personal, professional, and institutional values.

Finally, platform governance significantly shaped centres’ communication strategies. Participants across provinces reported shadowbanning, content removal, or reduced visibility when posts included terms such as “rape,” “assault,” or “sex.” Automated moderation systems constrained the clarity and accuracy of messaging, leading staff to adopt euphemisms or alternative phrasing (e.g., “segsual violence”) to preserve reach. As one staff member summarized, “We have to find gentler ways to say things so the bots don’t hide us.” (P2) These adaptations illustrate the tension between maintaining fidelity to the realities of SA/IPV and navigating opaque algorithmic rules.

These findings show that social media communication in SA/IPV centres is shaped by layered negotiations across intersectional commitments, survivor-centered design practices, community dynamics, organizational politics, and platform governance. The work of “doing EDI” online is thus not only representational but also

infrastructural and relational, requiring ongoing judgment about safety, visibility, and voice.

## 5 Discussion and Conclusion

Our findings demonstrate that EDI practices in SA/IPV centres are not merely representational choices but deeply sociotechnical forms of work. Intersectional communication, trauma-informed language, and accessibility routines function as compensatory labor for platform-level design gaps—particularly the lack of sensitivity to safety-critical contexts, opaque automated moderation systems, and the uneven visibility imposed on survivor-support content. These dynamics show that maintaining an equity-centered presence online requires staff to continually negotiate what can be said, who will see it, and how safety and inclusivity are preserved across diverse survivor communities. To support this labor, platforms need trauma-sensitive visibility controls that prevent critical educational posts from being downranked or removed; clearer moderation transparency to indicate which linguistic patterns trigger content restrictions; and authoring tools with built-in accessibility and trauma-informed scaffolds such as alt-text suggestions or prompts for non-triggering phrasing.

These observations foreground a broader implication for HCI: equity-centered communication cannot be fully realized without attending to the infrastructural and algorithmic conditions of contemporary social media systems. Our analysis conceptualizes equity-oriented communication in SA/IPV contexts as compensatory sociotechnical labor—work that frontline staff must perform to correct platform-level blind spots related to trauma, visibility, and safety. This reframing extends trauma-informed social media research by illustrating how practitioners actively adapt, reinterpret, and subvert platform rules to protect marginalized survivors. While prior HCI scholarship has examined harassment, harmful interactions, and moderation bias [43, 48], our findings reveal how EDI values become operationalized in micro-level communication practices that respond dynamically to community stigma, institutional constraints, and unpredictable moderation systems.

This study focuses on the perspectives of staff rather than survivors, reflecting ethical considerations around emotional risk. Future work could expand this analysis by collaborating with survivors, platform designers, and policy stakeholders to prototype or evaluate trauma-informed moderation tools, or by conducting cross-platform comparisons and computational audits to further examine visibility dynamics. Taken together, this work offers a qualitative account of the everyday labor required to sustain safer and more equitable communication in SA/IPV support organizations and highlights pathways for designing social media infrastructures that better uphold trauma-informed and equity-centered values.

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